



ARGUMENT • INTERVENTION DESIGN

Design So the Behaviour Never Has to Happen

The most powerful behavioural solutions are the ones that remove the need for behaviour altogether. Why the field keeps forgetting this, and how to use it.

IN BRIEF

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Behavioural science is mostly about getting people to do things. This paper argues that its strongest results come from the opposite move: designing the system so that the desired outcome no longer depends on anyone doing anything. Defaults, elimination, automation and engineered constraints outperform persuasion, reminders and incentives by an order of magnitude, and they keep working when attention, motivation and memory run out. A behaviour that does not need to happen cannot fail to happen. Before designing any intervention, ask whether the behaviour can be designed away.

1. The bias in the question

Every behaviour-change brief begins the same way. "How do we get people to..." Save more. Recycle. Use the new system. Fill in the form. Take the medication. The question already contains an assumption: that the outcome we want requires a person to act, and that our job is to make them act. The whole apparatus of the field, from nudges to incentives to training, is built on that assumption.

But the outcome is what the organisation wants. The behaviour is merely one route to it. And behaviour is an expensive, unreliable route. It draws on attention, which is scarce. It draws on motivation, which fluctuates. It draws on memory, which fails. It has to happen again tomorrow, and the day after, for as long as the outcome matters. Every intervention that works through behaviour inherits all of this fragility.

The question is not "how do we get people to do X?" It is "how do we get the outcome that X was supposed to produce?" Sometimes the answer still involves X. Often it does not.

2. The evidence that no-behaviour beats behaviour

The clearest demonstration is the default effect. Johnson and Goldstein's comparison of organ-donation rates across European countries found consent rates near 100 percent where donation was the default and people had to opt out, against rates between 4 and 28 percent in otherwise similar countries where people had to opt in (Johnson & Goldstein, 2003). Decades of information campaigns had moved the opt-in countries a few percentage points. A change to the form moved the outcome by more than seventy.

Retirement saving tells the same story. Madrian and Shea found that automatic enrolment raised participation in a US company's 401(k) plan from around 37 percent to 86 percent among new hires (Madrian & Shea, 2001). The UK's national auto-enrolment policy, introduced from 2012, lifted

workplace pension participation among eligible employees from around 55 percent to close to 90 percent. Financial education, matching contributions and reminder campaigns had been tried for years, with modest results. Removing the need to enrol worked immediately and permanently.

Public health has known this longer than behavioural economics has. Water fluoridation reduced tooth decay without asking anyone to brush differently. Lead was removed from petrol rather than drivers being asked to avoid it. Seatbelt use rose with laws and reminders, but the injury outcome shifted most when airbags and crumple zones protected people whether they buckled up or not. Occupational safety formalised the principle as the hierarchy of controls: eliminate the hazard first, substitute it second, engineer it out third, and only then rely on administrative rules and personal protective equipment, which require behaviour. The hierarchy is ordered by effectiveness, and behaviour sits at the bottom.

THE PATTERN

Every time a field has compared "change the person" against "change the system so the person need not change", the system wins, and it keeps winning after the campaign budget is gone.

3. Why it works: the arithmetic of reliability

Suppose an outcome requires a behaviour to happen at a given moment, and suppose the person notices the cue 80 percent of the time, is motivated 80 percent of the time they notice, and is able to act 80 percent of the time they are motivated. The behaviour happens about half the time. Improve each factor to 90 percent with a strong intervention and the behaviour happens 73 percent of the time. Now suppose the outcome must be sustained daily for a year. Even the improved version fails on roughly one day in four.

Now remove the behaviour. The outcome happens 100 percent of the time, on the first day and the last, for the disengaged employee and the enthusiastic one, in the week after the launch and the year after everyone has forgotten it. There is no version of persuasion that competes with that. The behaviour-free design is not a slightly better intervention; it belongs to a different class.

It is also fairer. Interventions that work through behaviour reward people who already have attention, motivation and capacity to spare. They widen gaps. Defaults and structural changes deliver the outcome to everyone, including the people the behavioural approach would have left behind.

4. The hierarchy of behavioural controls

Borrowing from occupational safety, we can order behavioural solutions by how much they depend on the person acting. The higher the tier, the less behaviour is needed and the more reliable the outcome.

Tier	Move	Behaviour required	Examples
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1. Eliminate	Remove the need for the outcome-producing behaviour entirely	None	Auto-enrolment; automatic software updates; direct debit; pre-filled tax returns
2. Default	Make the desired outcome what happens if nobody acts	Only to deviate	Opt-out organ donation; green energy tariff as default; double-sided printing as default
3. Constrain	Make the undesired outcome impossible or hard	Only to work around	Interlocks; forced-choice forms; speed bumps; smaller plates; single-use bags removed from tills
4. Simplify	Reduce the effort, steps and attention the behaviour needs	Reduced	One-click checkout; recycling bin next to the desk bin; prescription delivered to the door
5. Prompt	Cue the behaviour at the right moment	Full	Reminders; signage; nudges; notifications
6. Persuade	Change motivation, beliefs or knowledge	Full, plus ongoing	Campaigns; training; incentives; education

Most behavioural work happens in tiers 5 and 6. Most behavioural results come from tiers 1 to 3. The mismatch is the central inefficiency of the field.

5. Why we keep forgetting

If the top of the hierarchy is so effective, why does practice cluster at the bottom? Four reasons recur.

- **The brief arrives pre-framed.** By the time a behavioural team is involved, someone has already decided that the problem is that people do not do X. Reframing to the outcome means challenging the client's diagnosis, which is uncomfortable.
- **Structural changes belong to someone else.** Changing a default in a form requires the owner of the form. Removing a step requires the owner of the process. Behavioural teams are often given a communications budget and no authority over systems, so they do what their budget allows.
- **Visible effort feels like responsibility.** A campaign shows that the organisation tried. A changed default is invisible. Leaders who need to be seen acting prefer the visible option even when it is the weaker one.

- **Behaviour change is intellectually attractive.** Understanding why people act is fascinating.

Moving a checkbox is not. Professionals gravitate to the interesting problem, not the effective one.

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6. The ethical objection, taken seriously

Designing so that behaviour is unnecessary can sound like removing choice. Sometimes that is precisely the objection that should stop a design: people have a right to make decisions about their bodies, their money and their data, and an outcome imposed by a system they cannot see or leave is not a good outcome, however desirable it looks from the boardroom.

Three tests keep the approach honest. First, is the outcome one the affected person would choose on reflection, and could easily reverse? Defaults pass this test; hidden constraints often do not. Second, is the design transparent? A default that is disclosed and reversible respects autonomy more than a persuasion campaign that works by exploiting biases. Third, who benefits when the behaviour is removed? Removing the need for a customer to cancel a subscription is a very different act from removing the need for a patient to remember a dose. The same design move can serve the person or the organisation against the person, and the practitioner's job is to know which.

7. How to apply it inside CLEAR

The CLEAR framework's Leverage step asks teams to map the system around a behaviour before designing any intervention. This is where behaviour-free design belongs. The map reveals which steps, forms, settings and structures currently require the person to act, and which of those could be changed so they do not. A disciplined version of the step asks, for each behaviour on the map:

1. What outcome is this behaviour for?
2. Could the outcome be produced without the behaviour (eliminate)?
3. Could the outcome be what happens when nobody acts (default)?
4. Could the undesired alternative be made impossible or costly (constrain)?
5. Only if none of the above: how do we make the behaviour easier, cued and motivated?

The Experiment step then tests the structural change on a small scale, exactly as it would test a nudge. Structural changes are not exempt from evidence. Defaults can be reversed by annoyed users, constraints can be worked around, and eliminations can have side effects the map did not show. But when they hold, they hold at a scale that behavioural interventions rarely reach, and they hold without anyone having to remember.

8. Conclusion

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The most powerful behavioural solution is the one in which no behaviour is required. This is not a rejection of behavioural science but its most rigorous conclusion: if attention, motivation and memory are the bottlenecks, the best design is the one that does not route through them. Practitioners should treat persuasion as the last resort it is in every other safety-critical field, and should measure their success not by how many people they moved but by how many people no longer need to be moved at all.

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